

MIG-10

Migrant Interview: Inclusion and Xenophobia

Interviewee Profile

Interview code: MIG-10

Age: 33

Gender: Male

Country of origin: South Korea

Host country: United States

Years in host country: 6

Occupation: Graduate Researcher

Interview

Q1. Can you tell me about your journey and what brought you to your host country?

A: I came to the United States six years ago to pursue a PhD in biochemistry at an American research university. American institutions lead the world in my particular field, and the research opportunities, the funding, the laboratories, the calibre of collaborators, were simply unmatched by anything available to me back home. South Korea's academic environment, while excellent in many ways, is intensely competitive and quite rigidly hierarchical, and I found myself seeking greater intellectual freedom and more room to pursue my own scientific ideas. I arrived on a student visa, alone, knowing that my ability to stay would depend entirely on my performance and on navigating a complex immigration system, which added a constant undercurrent of pressure to everything.

Q2. What does 'inclusion' mean to you personally?

A: Inclusion means being recognised and credited for my genuine research contributions, without my ideas being overlooked or quietly attributed to others simply because of my accent or my more reserved, less self-promoting manner. It shows itself when I am invited to collaborate as a full equal, when the academic community actively values the diverse perspectives that international scholars bring rather than merely tolerating our presence for the labour we provide. Belonging, for me, is the feeling that I have a real and secure future here, a place in the scientific community and the country, rather than existing in a state of temporary and conditional tolerance that could be withdrawn at any moment depending on visa policy or circumstance.

Q3. Have you experienced xenophobia or discrimination? Can you describe it?

A: I have experienced xenophobia, and it intensified sharply and frighteningly during the pandemic, when anti-Asian hate surged across the country in an alarming way. I was verbally harassed on the street more than once, and for the first time in my life I genuinely felt unsafe simply walking around as an Asian person, hyperaware of the looks and comments directed at me. Beyond those acute incidents, there is the more persistent, low-level experience of being treated as a 'perpetual foreigner,' where, despite my fluency and my years here, people express surprise that I speak English well, or ask where I am really from, subtly reinforcing that I am seen as not quite belonging no matter how long I stay.

Q4. What have been the biggest challenges in adapting to your new country?

A: The biggest challenge for me was the significant cultural difference in communication styles; American academia strongly rewards assertiveness, confident self-promotion, and speaking up readily, all of which felt genuinely uncomfortable and even improper coming from Korea's more modest and deferential culture, where such behaviour can seem arrogant. Learning to advocate for myself and my work without feeling that I was violating my own upbringing took real, conscious effort. On top of that, visa uncertainties loomed constantly over everything, making any kind of long-term planning stressful and provisional, and the relentless pressure to secure sponsorship and status while simultaneously excelling academically was immense and never fully let up throughout my studies.

Q5. How would you describe your experience in the workplace or professional environment?

A: My research laboratory is genuinely international and intellectually stimulating, filled with talented colleagues from all over the world, which creates an atmosphere where being foreign is entirely normal rather than exceptional. My advisor is supportive and has invested in my development, and I feel respected for the quality of my work. Academia, at least within the sciences, tends to be considerably more meritocratic and diverse than many other sectors, valuing results and rigour over background, and this has made my professional experience largely positive and rewarding, a real refuge and source of belonging, despite the external hostilities and pressures I have faced outside the lab in the wider society.

Q6. How do you balance maintaining your cultural identity with integrating into the host society?

A: I maintain my Korean identity through food, which connects me viscerally to home, through the language, and through staying in close and regular contact with the Korean community here and with my family back in Korea. I celebrate the Korean holidays and follow Korean culture, news, and developments closely, so that I do not drift away from my roots. At the same time, I have gradually adopted a degree of American directness and individualism, particularly in professional contexts where it is necessary. I feel Korean at my core, in my values and my sense of self, but increasingly bicultural in my outlook and my ways of operating, able to move between the two modes as the situation requires.

Q7. How do you feel the media portrays migrants from your background?

A: American media has improved somewhat in its representation of Asians in recent years, with more visible and varied portrayals than there once were, but Asians are still frequently stereotyped as perpetual foreigners, as nerds, or as the so-called model minority. That model minority myth is particularly insidious and harmful, because it erases the real struggles and diversity of Asian experience while being used to pit Asian communities against other minority groups in a divisive way. The pandemic demonstrated with brutal clarity how quickly and completely we can be turned into scapegoats when it is convenient, how thin the acceptance can prove to be, which was a sobering and frightening lesson for many of us.

Q8. Have integration programs or community support been helpful in your experience?

A: As an international student and scholar, I relied heavily on the university's international office, which was helpful with the practicalities of visas, documentation, and initial orientation, but which offered relatively little in the way of deeper cultural integration or emotional support. There were very

few programmes that genuinely addressed the specific isolation that international scholars often experience, the loneliness of being far from home in a demanding environment. American universities are eager to recruit us for our talent and the work we do, and they benefit greatly from our presence, but they frequently under-support our personal adjustment and our wellbeing, treating us as productive units rather than as whole people who are far from everyone they know.

Q9. How has the next generation (or younger migrants) adapted compared to you?

A: I do not have children yet, but I think a great deal about the Asian-American generation growing up and navigating questions of identity in a country that, too often, still treats them as fundamentally foreign despite their being American by birth and upbringing. I have watched Korean-American friends, born and raised here, struggle with a sense of belonging and with the same tiresome questions about where they are really from. My hope is that future generations will face considerably less of the 'perpetual foreigner' treatment than we do now, less of that constant subtle interrogation of their right to belong, and that they will simply be accepted as the Americans they are.

Q10. In your opinion, what would help reduce xenophobia in society?

A: To reduce xenophobia, America must confront anti-Asian racism honestly and directly, because it is so often overlooked, minimised, or left out of the broader conversation about prejudice entirely, as though it did not fully count. Education about Asian-American history and about the long and substantial contributions of Asian communities to this country is crucial for correcting that erasure. Solidarity among all minority groups, rather than the division that the model minority myth encourages, is genuinely powerful and important. And, as ever, personal relationships across cultures, which are common in the diverse environment of universities, reliably reduce prejudice and build real mutual understanding over time, one relationship at a time.

Q11. What are your hopes and dreams for the future?

A: I hope to secure a faculty position and to contribute meaningfully to scientific research, ideally in a way that might build bridges between American and Korean institutions and researchers, drawing on my connection to both. I want to mentor future international scientists who will face the same challenges of communication, isolation, and immigration that I have faced, and to make their path a little smoother than mine was. Looking further ahead, I hope to build a permanent life here, to finally move beyond the perpetual uncertainty of visas and temporary status, while maintaining strong and living ties to my Korean roots and to the family I left behind.

Q12. What advice would you give to new migrants arriving in your host country?

A: My advice to newcomers, particularly students and scholars, is to adapt your communication style to the new environment without losing your authentic self in the process; learn to advocate for your work and speak up, even when it feels uncomfortable, because it is often necessary here. Build a support network deliberately, both within your own cultural community and beyond it, because isolation is a real danger in this demanding world. Understand the visa and immigration system thoroughly and plan carefully around it, because uncertainty there colours everything. And take active care of your mental health amid the considerable pressures, because no achievement is worth sacrificing your wellbeing entirely.